

You already know the team is stretched. Here is the number behind it.

Most owners track the salary they are not paying. Almost nobody tracks what the empty seat is costing them.

39-44 days

median time to fill a
non-executive role (SHRM 2026
/ 2025)

\$5,475

average hard cost per hire,
before anyone's time (SHRM
2025)

50-200%

of annual salary to replace an
employee who leaves (SHRM)

10 days

how fast we can have your new
professional in the seat

Five costs that never show up as a line item

- **Senior time covering gaps.** Your controller closing AP. Your ops manager running track and trace at 9 pm. Priced at their rate, not the vacant one.
- **Overtime and burnout.** The people covering the seat are your best people, and they are the ones who leave next.
- **Deferred growth.** The account you did not chase, the lane you did not open, the property you did not take on because there was no bandwidth.
- **Service slippage.** Slower responses, missed follow-ups, and the clients who quietly stop calling.
- **The re-hire loop.** Every replacement restarts the 39-44 day clock and the cost per hire.

Worked example: one open bookkeeper seat

Component	Basis	Cost
Work not getting done while open	\$50,670 salary / 220 days x 44 days open	\$10,134
Hard cost per hire	SHRM 2025 non-executive average	\$5,475
Ramp-up drag	3 months at 50% productivity	\$6,334
Overtime and senior coverage	Your figure	
Total, before overtime		\$21,943

That is a conservative estimate for a single back-office seat. Multiply by the number of open or about-to-be-open roles and add a year of turnover risk.

Your worksheet

Fill this in for one role you have open or are about to lose. Bring it to our call and we will happily price the alternative right next to it.

A. Annual salary of the role	_____	<i>US base</i>
B. Daily value of the role (A / 220)	_____	
C. Days the seat has been, or will be, open	_____	<i>SHRM median: 39-44</i>
D. Work not getting done (B x C)	_____	
E. Recruiting spend to fill it	_____	<i>SHRM avg \$5,475, or 20-25% agency fee</i>
F. Senior hours spent covering, x their hourly rate	_____	
G. Overtime paid to the team covering	_____	
H. Revenue or accounts deferred because of the gap	_____	<i>Your estimate</i>
I. Ramp-up drag (A / 12 x 3 x 0.5)	_____	
Cost of staying understaffed (D + E + F + G + H + I)	_____	<i>per open seat</i>

The alternative, priced

	US in-house hire	Working with us
Time to first candidates	Weeks	Days: minimum three vetted candidates with written summaries and interview clips
Time in seat	39-44 days median	As little as 10 days after you choose
Upfront cost	\$5,475+ per hire, or a 20-25% agency fee	None
Ongoing cost (bookkeeper)	\$72,400 / yr loaded	\$1,600 - \$2,300 / mo all-in (market range)
If it does not work out	Restart the clock and the spend	Zero Risk replacement at no additional cost
Contract	Employment	Month-to-month

Next step: a Zero Risk consultation

We would love to hear what your team is carrying right now. In a relaxed 30-minute call we will map what a 10/10 hire looks like for the role you have in mind. No upfront fee, no long-term contract. If it fits, we can have you interviewing vetted candidates within days.